

Can Filial Piety Be Automated? AI Voice Assistants and the Cost of Leaving the Village

Why Are We Talking About This Topic?

Hiếu Thảo and the Expectation of Staying Close

In Vietnamese culture, taking care of one's parents is known to be one of the highest moral obligations. More specifically, this value is known as filial piety, or *Hiếu Thảo* in the Vietnamese language. Traditionally, it is an expectation for adult children to stay close to their home village so they can look after their family members as they grow older. This expectation has long been a part of Vietnamese culture, and it shows how Vietnamese families have supported each other for decades. However, because of rapid industrialization, many young adults are choosing to migrate from rural provinces to major manufacturing hubs in order to have more economic stability. Consequently, this change has caused many elderly parents to live alone in rural areas.

This change is also happening at a rapid pace; according to data from Vietnam's General Statistics Office, 4.43 million older people, about 35 percent of all older Vietnamese, live alone, live with only other older people, or live in a household containing only older people and grandchildren under fifteen (General Statistics Office and UNFPA 25). Additionally, over 63 percent of all elderly people in the country live in rural zones where young workers are leaving (General Statistics Office and UNFPA 15). In order to solve this problem, tech companies are moving toward building AI automated chatbots. For instance, a Vietnamese technology company, OLLI Technology Corporation, built a smart speaker named OLLI Maika that features a native Vietnamese voice assistant, which families can place in the homes of their elderly parents to act as daily companions ("Loa thông minh là gì?"). Moreover, the software has proved its capabilities by understanding Vietnamese accurately and sending automated reminders so elderly parents remember to take their medicine on time ("Loa thông minh là gì?").

The Philosophical Predicament

Even though AI companions might potentially be a solution for isolated elderly individuals, they introduce a philosophical predicament. More specifically, when a smart assistant becomes the primary companion for an isolated parent, we need to ask whether a smart AI assistant can truly fulfill our moral duties. This essay examines whether AI voice assistants preserve or erode the bond between young adults and their parents.

Albert Borgmann's Argument

The Device Paradigm and Focal Practices

The first argument stems from the ideas of Albert Borgmann, a philosopher who spent his life studying how automated systems change human behavior. Borgmann developed a famous concept called the device paradigm to show how technology alters a person's relationship with the world (Borgmann 40–48). Furthermore, he states that traditional life is full of deep activities that he calls focal practices (Borgmann 196–202). More precisely, a focal practice is an action that requires an individual's personal time and effort to carry out, such as spending time talking to and taking care of elderly parents. Borgmann adds that these practices are valuable because they force a person to engage with the people around them and build genuine character (Borgmann 204).

Borgmann points out that with the implementation of technology in our daily lives, devices are now capable of giving us a final product instantly without making a person do any of the hard work (Borgmann 42–44). For instance, a microwave gives a person a reward of hot food without actually having to cook, and a heating vent provides a person with warmth without having to work to receive it.

Eldercare as a Focal Practice

Under the philosophy of Albert Borgmann, when this is applied to elderly care in Vietnam, physically taking care of one's parents by making their meals or cleaning their house is a focal practice. Additionally, these activities only have value if a person is physically present and sacrificing his or her own time. Therefore, when an AI companion is introduced, it provides a commodity and communication for an elderly individual so that their son or daughter does not have to call and help as often. Borgmann's philosophy warns us that when we incorporate AI assistants into moral practices, we unintentionally destroy the discipline that makes the activity meaningful (Borgmann 207–210).

Nel Noddings's Argument

Care as a Relationship

Another important argument was put forward by Nel Noddings, a philosopher known for developing the ethics of care. Noddings explains that moral actions are not just about following rules or checking items off a list (Noddings 14–19). Instead, they are about real human relationships and responsiveness. Consequently, according to Noddings, for "care" to be valuable, the person who is carrying out the care must be psychologically present and responsive to the feelings of the other person (Noddings 24–30).

Why a Speaker Cannot Be Present

When we look at AI chatbots or voice assistants, they do not actually participate in the relationship of caring for elderly people. To be more specific, even though an AI assistant speaker like Maika can speak with a friendly voice that replicates a regional accent, it does not actually have any consciousness or emotions. This

is because AI assistant speakers are usually constructed through algorithmic lines of code that match audio files to the sound of a human voice. This means that the AI does not actually care whether elderly people are lonely; it is only performing actions that it was programmed to do.

The One-Sided Relationship

Under the ideas of Nel Noddings, when using an AI voice to keep aging parents company, the relationship remains one-sided and the action of care does not carry genuine moral value (Noddings 32–35). This is due to the fact that elderly people are interacting with a machine that simulates care and love, meaning that the introduction of AI assistant chatbots alters the essence of family closeness. Some young adults are choosing to replace real face-to-face relationships with a technological proxy, believing the technology is capable of replacing moral duties. Overall, Noddings' ideas warn us that we cannot fulfill the duty of *Hiếu Thảo* through a smart device because a piece of hardware, unlike family members, is taking care of the elderly not because it loves them, but because it was programmed to do so. Therefore, when we choose to replace sincere relationships with an automated proxy, the generational bond weakens.

Counterpoint: Dewey and the Adaptation of Tradition

Ethics as Tools for Real Problems

However, not every philosopher believes that the incorporation of AI assistant chatbots is disadvantageous. John Dewey, an American philosopher who founded a school of thought called pragmatism, contends that moral values and traditions are not made to persist unchanged (Dewey 156–160). In particular, Dewey claimed that ethics are tools meant to help people solve real-world problems in order to facilitate daily life (Dewey 161). Dewey adds that circumstances change drastically due to modern shifts like industrialization and migration, so traditions must change accordingly to stay relevant (Dewey 162–165).

As a result, if we apply John Dewey's philosophy to the current eldercare situation in Vietnam, sticking to the old tradition of physical presence can create hardships for a household. For instance, data from the General Statistics Office reveals a significant rural labor surplus: while the Vietnamese agricultural sector only requires 19 million people, there are over 25.5 million individuals who need a job in rural areas, which means many young adults in rural areas are left unemployed (General Statistics Office, Migration 35). This problem encourages the movement toward urban economic zones, where the Southeast region attracts over 50 percent of all migrants for job opportunities and higher wages (General Statistics Office, Migration 38). Consequently, if a person refuses to leave their village, their family might struggle to afford basic food or medical treatment. From Dewey's perspective, using a smart speaker like Maika is a practical way to carry out filial piety, allowing children to monitor and keep elderly parents company while still handling financial needs from afar (Dewey 168). In essence, for Dewey, morality is about finding solutions to problems rather than being rigid with old traditions.

Holding the Views Together

Two Standards for Judging the Device

When we analyze this dilemma, there is a clear tension between preserving deep cultural values and adapting to economic change. Based on the views of philosophers Borgmann and Noddings, enabling AI to handle family relationships can ruin the meaning of genuine care and potentially fail to carry out filial piety (Borgmann 207; Noddings 34). These philosophers remind us that an electronic device cannot replicate the sincerity and warmth that come from direct human contact. Conversely, philosopher John Dewey points out that in a world of constant change, it is necessary for traditions to adapt in order for a household to thrive (Dewey 165).

Ultimately, whether a voice assistant preserves or breaks intergenerational bonds depends on how a person defines the boundary of filial piety. More specifically, an AI algorithm cannot feel empathy or offer true physical presence, so when an AI chatbot conducts daily check-ins, it does not provide real emotional reciprocity. However, an AI assistant can help a person carry out filial piety by enabling them to provide company and monitor a parent's health while earning a living wage from afar. All in all, it is up to modern families to decide whether filial duty resides in the personal presence of adult children or in securing the financial resources essential to the household.

Works Cited

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